'Hocus Pocus' Tops Disney+ as Halloween Nears

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With Halloween just around the corner, a 33-year-old movie is once again one of the most popular things to watch. 'Hocus Pocus,' a 1993 Disney film, is the No. 1 movie on Disney+, according to FlixPatrol, a website that tracks **streaming** charts.

The 96-minute movie stars Sarah Jessica Parker, Bette Midler and Kathy Najimy as the Sanderson Sisters, a **trio** of wicked witches from the 1600s. In the story, a teenage boy named Max and his little sister Dani move to the town of Salem, Massachusetts. Max, who is having trouble fitting in, accidentally brings the witches back. Max, Dani, their new friend Allison and a talking cat named Thackery Binx must work together to stop them. The film was directed by Kenny Ortega.

The movie was not a hit at first. It came out in theaters in July, an odd time for a Halloween film, and it disappointed at the **box office**. But over the years it became a favorite, especially for people who were kids in the 1990s. It played again and again on cable TV, and many families now watch it every October.

In 2023, for its 30th **anniversary**, 'Hocus Pocus' even returned to the top 10 at movie theaters. Last year, both the original and its **sequel**, 'Hocus Pocus 2,' which came out on Disney+, were in the **streaming** top 10 in the days before Halloween.

Fans have more to look forward to. Disney is working on a third movie, which would turn the story into a **trilogy**. The writer of the original article hopes 'Hocus Pocus 3' will play in theaters instead of going straight to **streaming**.

Word Treasure

streaming -- Watching movies or shows over the internet instead of on a disc or regular TV.
trio -- A group of three.
anniversary -- The date that marks a certain number of years since something happened.
sequel -- A movie or book that continues the story of an earlier one.
trilogy -- A set of three related movies or books.
box office -- The money a movie earns from ticket sales in theaters.

Background you need

Streaming services like Disney+ let people watch movies and shows over the internet whenever they want.

Websites track which titles are watched most and publish charts that rank them.

Some movies that earn little in theaters later become favorites when families watch them again and again, often around a holiday.

Studios sometimes make sequels when an older movie keeps a large group of fans.

Break it down

LEAD: 'Hocus Pocus' is the No. 1 movie on Disney+ as Halloween nears
KEY FACT: FlixPatrol ranks the 1993 film first
+- WHO: Sarah Jessica Parker, Bette Midler and Kathy Najimy as the Sanderson Sisters
+- STORY: Max, Dani, Allison and Thackery Binx try to stop the witches in Salem
HISTORY: Box-office disappointment in July, later a family favorite
EVIDENCE: Back in the theater top 10 in 2023; original and sequel both in streaming top 10 last year
WHAT'S NEXT: Disney is working on 'Hocus Pocus 3'

Why it matters

The movie shows how a film that disappointed at first can become a beloved family tradition, and its popularity is pushing Disney to make another sequel.

Test what you remember

1. Where is 'Hocus Pocus' currently the No. 1 movie?

- (A) Movie theaters
- (B) Netflix
- (C) Disney+
- (D) Cable TV

2. In what year did 'Hocus Pocus' first come out?

- (A) 2023
- (B) 1983
- (C) 2003
- (D) 1993

3. Who are the Sanderson Sisters?

- (A) Three wicked witches from the 1600s
- (B) Max's teachers
- (C) Three talking cats
- (D) Allison's cousins

4. Why was July an odd time for the movie's release?

- (A) School was in session
- (B) Theaters were closed
- (C) It was too hot to film
- (D) It is a Halloween film

5. What happened for the movie's 30th anniversary in 2023?

- (A) It was remade as a cartoon
- (B) It was removed from streaming
- (C) It won an award
- (D) It returned to the top 10 at movie theaters

6. What is Disney working on now?

- (A) A 'Hocus Pocus' theme park
- (B) A video game
- (C) A third 'Hocus Pocus' movie
- (D) A TV news show

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: A 4: D 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Writer of the original article: Hopes 'Hocus Pocus 3' will play in theaters instead of going straight to streaming.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):